

Measuring Agenda-Setting in Online News Media: The Case of State Capture in South Africa

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1 Introduction

The media’s role as a watchdog is a cornerstone to democracy; yet this normative ideal is contingent upon external factors such as political pressure, ownership structures, and market incentives. In post-apartheid South Africa, the quality of journalism has been severely tested by the state capture phenomenon. This decade-long saga, centered on former President Jacob Zuma and the Gupta family, implicated the very institutions that were meant to safeguard democracy, including the public broadcaster, the SABC. This study asks: how did South Africa’s online news outlets exercise their media agenda-setting function pertaining to this issue? Employing a mixed-methods approach, we analyse over 800,000 online news articles from 2010–2025, measuring both salience (first-level agenda-setting) and tonal framing (second-level agenda-setting) of the state capture narrative across five major online news sources. The analysis reveals a clear divergence: independent outlets’ coverage was markedly more critical and highly salient, while the public broadcaster’s was delayed, infrequent, and evidently neutral in tone. Business-focused newspapers occupy a middle-ground. These results provide an important quantitative establishment of the media’s role in the dissemination of the state capture narrative and how the structural position of an outlet affects its reporting.

2 Background

2.1 The Media Environment of South Africa

Wasserman (2020) describes the South African media landscape as a structure operating in three tiers—public, commercial, and community media—each designed to serve a different part of a socially and economically heterogeneous population. The nation’s public media entity, the South African Broadcasting Corporation (SABC), was inherited by the newly

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elected African National Congress (ANC) in 1994, transforming the broadcaster from a state broadcaster to a public entity. Under apartheid rule, the SABC was regularly used as a propaganda distribution channel and, following the logic of segregation, supplied separate streams of media to different ethnic groups.

Since 1994, the start of South Africa’s democratic age, the public broadcaster was expected to leverage its bequeathed infrastructure to supply fair, honest, and affordable news to a population with pressing information needs. Before long, however, the SABC found itself entangled in a string of corruption and mismanagement allegations. The indictments included the likes of blacklisting political commentators around the 2009 elections, to censorship and editorial interference over the Marikana Massacre news cycle in 2012 to 2013 (Nodoba, 2024). This raised the question about whether or not the public media authority truly serves the people, or whether it had returned to its former function as a government mouthpiece. Nevertheless, the SABC remains a primary source of news for the majority of the country, mainly due to its widespread accessibility and affordability, and its importance in the dissemination of news should, therefore, not be understated.

Despite the apparent variety of commercial media in South Africa, ownership is concentrated in a handful of large conglomerates (Wasserman, 2020), a tendency that is common in media industries around the world. South Africa’s most notable tech and media giant, Naspers, owns a large number of online news retailers under its umbrella business, Media24, which in turn owns household names such as News24 or its Afrikaans counterpart, Netwerk24. Furthermore, the conglomerate enjoyed long-term dominance in television through its ownership of Multichoice, but the company was eventually spun off on the Johannesburg Stock Exchange (JSE) and later acquired by the French company Canal+ (Bhana, 2025).

Arena Holdings is another major player in the news media sphere, owning titles such as Sunday Times, Business Day, Financial Mail, and more. Online newspaper titles include TimesLIVE, BusinessLIVE, SowetanLIVE, and more.

In the commercial news environment, two publishers have built their reputations upon critical reporting and detailed analyses. The Daily Maverick—independently owned and funded through reader donations, grants or advertising—has been recognised internationally for its investigative journalism. The Mail & Guardian, as of 2017, is owned by the New York-based not-for-profit, Media Development Investment Fund, which claims that their objective is to support “independent media in emerging markets” (Mail & Guardian, 2017). Since community media as per Wasserman (2020)’s definition is not of a core interest to this report, we consider these two sources to constitute the third tier of media—those which are free to read and intend to serve the community at large.

Online news in South Africa only truly emerged in the 2010s. According to the World Bank (2026)’s World Development Indicators, South Africa’s internet penetration share exceeded 20 percent for the first time in 2010 and reached 76 percent in 2023. The steep slope over the years between, as shown in Figure 1, suggests a significant increase of access to online news media. Figure 2 shows data from the Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism where survey respondents are asked what types of media they use to access the news (Roper et al., 2025). Results from recent years suggest that the majority of the sample

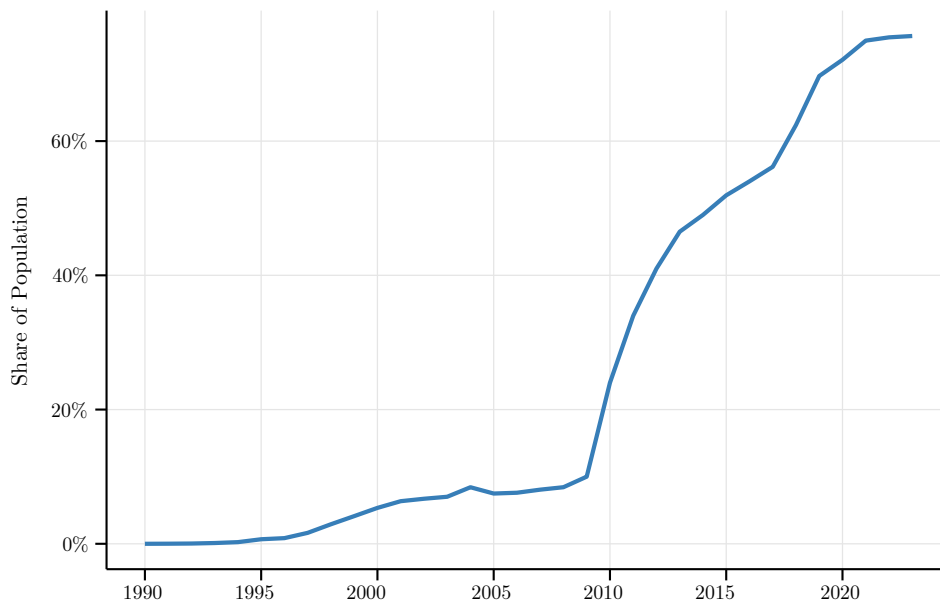


Figure 1: Share of Population Using the Internet, 1990–2023

Notes: Data sourced from World Bank (2026).

rely on online sources or television. Most online news sources now make use of social media platforms to advertise their articles or disseminate short-form videos or synopses of their works. One could make a broad assumption, therefore, that analysis of one medium may provide insights into the dynamics of the other.

According to the Reuters Digital News Report ((Roper et al., 2025)), SABC News remains the most used traditional news source (TV, print, and radio). In terms of online news, it remains a significant player, securing third place with 40 percent of weekly online reach.¹ This number trails behind eNCA online (another freely available commercial news source) with 45 percent reach, and News24 with 58 percent reach. The other sources that are captured in our data—the Daily Maverick (12 percent), Mail & Guardian (10 percent), and TimesLIVE (10 percent)—all enjoy far less weekly readership when compared to the public broadcaster. Furthermore, responses on public opinion and brand trust show that the Daily Maverick and Mail & Guardian are perceived as less trustworthy than the SABC and sources of news owned by Arena Holdings (captured online in the BusinessLIVE archives).

The results displayed in Table 1 reveal a notably high level of public trust in the SABC. This may reflect a post-state capture correction in its perception (as the results are representative of a 2025 sample).² On the contrary, it could signal the enduring influence of its unparalleled affordability and reach that grants it an inherent power imbalance in the na-

¹Weekly online reach, in this case, is defined as the share of survey respondents that make use of the source *at least* once per week.

²Results of previous Digital News Reports, however, closely mimic those displayed here.

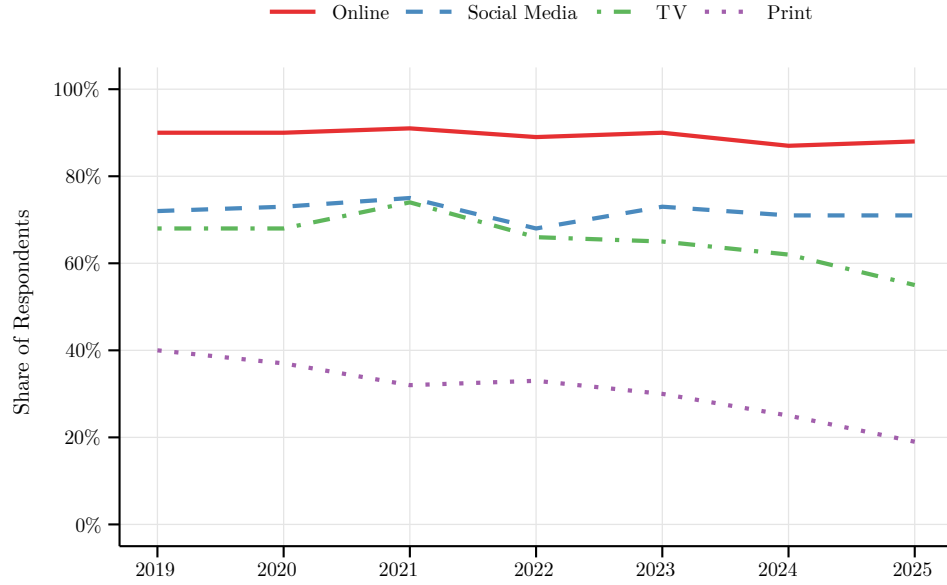


Figure 2: Share of Respondents Reporting Use of Media Type for News, 2019–2025

Notes: Data sourced from Roper et al. (2025).

tional media landscape. The following subsection examines the phenomenon of state capture, detailing the media’s dual role in both facilitating and challenging this system.

Table 1: Trust Levels for Selected South African News Brands, 2025.

Brand	Trust	Neither	Don’t Trust
SABC	75	13	12
TimesLIVE	67	21	13
Sunday Times	73	16	11
Sowetan	60	24	17
Daily Maverick	63	22	15
Mail & Guardian	67	21	12

Notes: Data sourced from Roper et al. (2025). Values represent shares (%) of respondents.

2.2 A Brief History of State Capture in South Africa

The significance of state capture and its lingering effects on the South African economy, governance, and press integrity cannot be overstated. Martin and Solomon (2016) aptly interpret state capture as the process wherein actors within the public and private sector fuse economic and political power to corruptly influence laws and policies for personal advantage. The South African case is argued to be inextricably linked to the political rise and tenure

of former President Jacob Zuma. Qualitative analysis of its chronology reveals a symbiotic relationship between political strategy, media manipulation, and institutional degradation, a process through which Zuma and the Gupta family sought to legitimise the illegitimate.

Zuma’s ascent to presidency in 2009 was itself a precursor to formal state capture that sounded alarm bells in countless South African households. Through a carefully engineered media and identity campaign—drawn from the populist playbook—Zuma managed to leverage allegations against him and portray these claims as smear campaigns orchestrated to bring down the country’s true leader. He framed himself as a victim of political conspiracy by then-president Thabo Mbeki and the Scorpions (Basson in De Waal, 2012), all the while emphasising the “100% Zulu-boy” narrative, painting the picture of an authentic, grass-roots candidate (Hoeane, 2010). His use of song and dance (e.g., the “Umshini-Wame” freedom song) outside courthouses during his rape trial, alongside an emphasis on customs and polygamy resonated with conservative rural voters.

These narratives were actively protected through legal intimidation of critical outlets like The Guardian and Sunday Times and the pulling of satirical documentaries from the SABC Davies (2009). That same SABC, however, was alleged by opposition party members to be a “serial offender in favour of the ANC” (Holomisa, cited in Mail & Guardian, 2008) demonstrating how partisan interests may have already infiltrated the public broadcaster.

Ultimately, the SABC was directly implicated by allegations of state capture in the Public Protector Thuli Madonsela’s 2016 *State of Capture* report—a report which was ultimately instigated by media investigations and subsequent parliamentary pressure (Madonsela, 2016). The report outlines how the Gupta family oligarchs influenced cabinet reshuffles, board appointments at state-owned enterprises (SOEs), and the awarding of state contracts. As quoted from the report: “[the] SABC has since entered into a partnership agreement with the New Age newspaper and government departments, including Ministers, are required to pay... to appear on SABC for purposes of communication with the nation” (Madonsela, 2016, p. 68)

This history establishes how the media played a central role in the battle for South Africa’s institutions. The following sections bridge the media agenda-setting framework to this setting and provide empirical analysis of the state capture agenda in the online news media from 2010 to 2025.

2.3 The Agenda-Setting Framework

This report firmly grounds itself in agenda-setting theory which found its naissance in the seminal work of Lippmann (1922). His contribution is the idea that the media shapes a “pseudo-environment” that influences the “pictures in our heads” or how we see (and, therefore, act) with the world around us. Followed over 50 years later by the landmark Chapel Hill study of McCombs and Shaw (1972), the field saw a dramatic shift by embracing the empirics, which firmly established agenda-setting as a major communication paradigm. Throughout this report, theory and definitions will be assumed commonly understood and little attention will be given to the definitions of agenda-setting terminology. Helpful reference material can be found in the works of Dearing and Rogers (1996) and McCombs (2004). These texts are

used to guide our study. The following section will briefly describe the empirical techniques to be employed and how these may aid our understanding of agenda-setting phenomena.

3 Empirical Methodology

3.1 Data

To empirically analyse the agenda-setting functions of online news media in the South African state capture narrative, this study uses an original panel dataset of online news articles from five major South African news organisations for the period 2010–2025. The primary variable of interest is the article text, which is available in full for the overwhelming majority of articles. When full text required a subscription, articles were included based on a synopsis of around 100 to 150 words, as these summaries should carry the narrative of the piece. Other fields in the dataset include the title, URL, and publication date.³

We scraped the data from each news source’s publicly available application programming interface (API) using the `requests` (v.2.31.0) library in Python. During the scraping process, several data-science techniques were employed: (1) *pagination* to ensure that the scraper pages backwards chronologically to the first available article (each API limits the number of articles that can be fetched with a single request, thereby necessitating such an approach), (2) *recursive request limiting* which increments the waiting time between requests for new pages to avoid throttling or rate limiting from the server, and (3) *parallel requests* to improve data processing speed relative to sequential processing. After validation and cleaning—i.e., ensuring that all articles are unique and contain sensible text of at least 50 words—the full dataset contains $N = 807,855$ online news articles.⁴ The full dataset is summarised in Table 2. The selection of these sources is based on data accessibility; attempts were made to scrape a wider range of news sources (such as IOL, News24, etc.), but ultimately proved unsuccessful. While the sources available provide a good balance of commercial, free-to-read, and public news sources, the absence of News24 (the market leader) and other diversifying sources limits the generalisability of these findings. Future research should aim to incorporate more online news sources.

3.2 Measuring The Media Agenda: First-Level Agenda-Setting

According to Dearing and Rogers (1996), there are two primary approaches to measuring any given agenda: (1) the hierarchy approach, and (2) the longitudinal approach. These approaches can be combined by measuring the relative importance of an agenda topic—as a share of total news articles that mention the issue—over time. Given the large sample size

³The author field was dropped from the dataset as some sources use internal IDs to identify authors. Without publicly available metadata or more elaborate data processing, the author field was rendered useless. Similarly, category descriptions and assignment differed across sources and were subject to the same issue of lacking publicly available metadata. This field was therefore dropped as well.

⁴Uniqueness is determined by cross-referencing article titles, URLs, and publication dates to ensure that a single unique key, the URL, remains.

Table 2: Summary of News Sources and Data Coverage

News Source	Articles (N)	Date Range (MM/YYYY)
BusinessLIVE	368,096	01/2010–09/2025
Business Tech	64,401	12/2011–12/2025
Daily Maverick	113,170	01/2010–09/2025
Mail & Guardian	122,420	01/2015–12/2025
South African Broadcasting Corporation	139,768	08/2010–12/2025
Total	807,855	2010–2025

of our data, an appropriate algorithm is required to filter articles efficiently while minimising the risk of type I and type II errors.

This study employs a regular expression (regex) matching approach. A specified regex pattern is matched against the text of each article, and a binary value $\alpha \in 0, 1$ is assigned: $\alpha = 1$ if the pattern matches any part of the text, and $\alpha = 0$ otherwise. The first pattern used to measure the prevalence of state capture in the media agenda is:

```
'state_capture': re.compile(
    r'(?<!\w)(state\s+capture|Zondo\s+(?:commission|report|inquiry)|'
    r'Gupta(?:s|\s)?\s+(?:family|leaks|influence|network)|'
    r'(Jacob|President)\s+Zuma(?:s)?\s+(?:era|administration)|'
    r'corruption\s+(?:scandal|inquiry|commission)|'
    r'(?:public|state)\s+enterprise\s+capture)(?!\w)',
    flags=re.IGNORECASE
)
```

Listing 1: Permissive state capture regex pattern.

This pattern flags articles containing exact phrases such as “state capture” or “Zondo commission,” as well as related phrases like “Gupta leaks,” “President Zuma administration,” or “corruption scandal.” It is therefore a permissive measure designed to minimise false negatives, albeit at the risk of increasing false positives. The permissive state capture pattern flagged 23,997 articles. Manual validation of select articles in this subset, however, shows promising prediction accuracy. A second, more permissive pattern was also developed including terms such as “bosasa,” “zupta,” and “guptagate.”

3.3 Measuring Sentiment: Second-Level Agenda-Setting

Beyond signaling *what* issues are important, the news media also shape *how* audiences think and feel about those issues. This second-level agenda-setting operates through framing, the placement of editorials and op-eds, and the use of emotive and evaluative language. Public response to media coverage thus depends not only on the salience of an issue, but also on its substance and tone McCombs (2004).

Assuming that aggregating the frequency of emotionally charged words can serve as a valid proxy measure for framing, then sentiment analysis (SA), or analogously opinion

mining, may offer a valuable toolkit for such an undertaking. SA is a natural language processing technique that provides a systematic method for quantifying linguistic tone across large text corpora (see Medhat et al. (2014) for a review). The SA process begins by sourcing a predefined sentiment dictionary that assigns polarity scores (positive, negative, or neutral) to words and phrases. SA then identifies these strings in texts and transforms qualitative nuances of tone and framing into measurable data.

In this study, we implement SA using the **syuzhet** package for R, and apply three widely used lexicons: **AFINN** Nielsen (2011), **bing** Hu and Liu (2004), and **nrc** Mohammad and Turney (2013). **AFINN** assigns a score of $s \in [-5, 5]$ to each affective word in the dictionary, with sentiment positivity/negativity corresponding to the sign of s . Similarly, **nrc** and **bing** assigns a binary scores to score words’ relative sentiments. To reduce the computational load and focus only on affectively meaningful terms, we remove stop words—words that have no semantic meaning, such as articles, or words that are used often in journalism but convey no emotion—from our data. The text is then transformed into a tidy format that improves the speed of the lexical analysis, after which sentiment scores are assigned. The results of these analyses, alongside other findings, are presented in the following section.

4 Results

Figure 3 shows the trajectory of media reporting on state capture in comparison to two other key political issues: broad-based black economic empowerment (BBBEE) and the loadshedding crisis. We aggregate data across all five news sources.

The first spike in state capture related reporting appears in March 2016, following the launch of a formal probe into state capture. This period coincided with the Constitutional Court’s ruling on the Nkandla scandal, in which Jacob Zuma and the National Assembly were found to have violated the constitution by failing to repay the state for non-security upgrades to the former president’s private home (Thamm, 2016). A second, more pronounced spike occurs in October 2016, immediately after the release of the Public Prosecutor’s *State of Capture* report on 14 October 2016 (Madonsela, 2016). That month, state capture coverage totalled 9 percent across all sources in the sample, rising to a peak of 11.6 percent in November 2016.

Another period of sustained high coverage is visible from June 2017. This coincides with the revelations of Bell Pottinger’s involvement in an astroturfing campaign that sought to stir up racial tensions by promoting a “white monopoly capital” narrative on social media Munusamy (2017). Over the following months, reporting on the issue remained high at over 6 percent per month until Zuma’s eventual resignation after being recalled by his party.

State capture continued to receive substantial attention in the newsroom around the turn of the decade, propelled mostly by the ongoing work and findings of the Zondo Commission. From March to May 2020, however, all three issues portrayed in the figure garnered little relative coverage in the news, evidently crowded out by reporting on the coronavirus pandemic.

Figure 4 visualises the differential reporting on state capture across sources as shares of

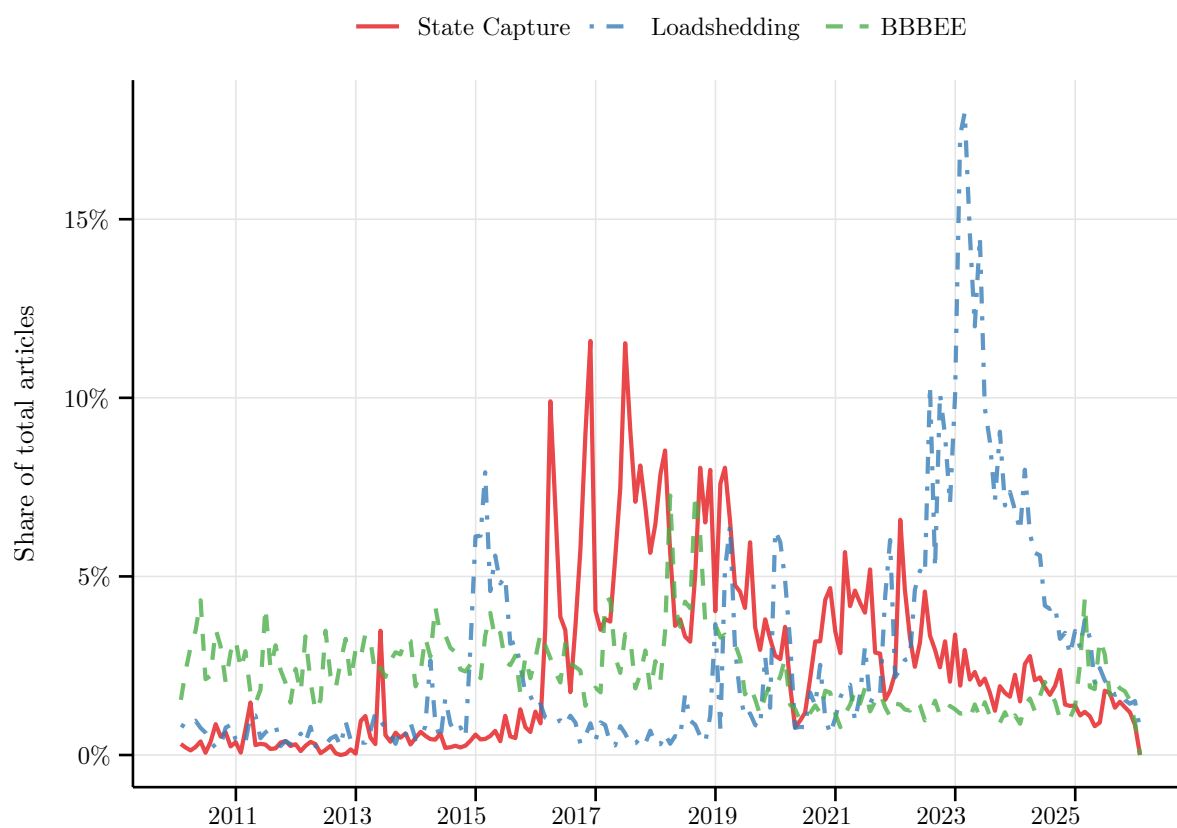


Figure 3: Major Agendas in the South African Online News Media, 2010–2025

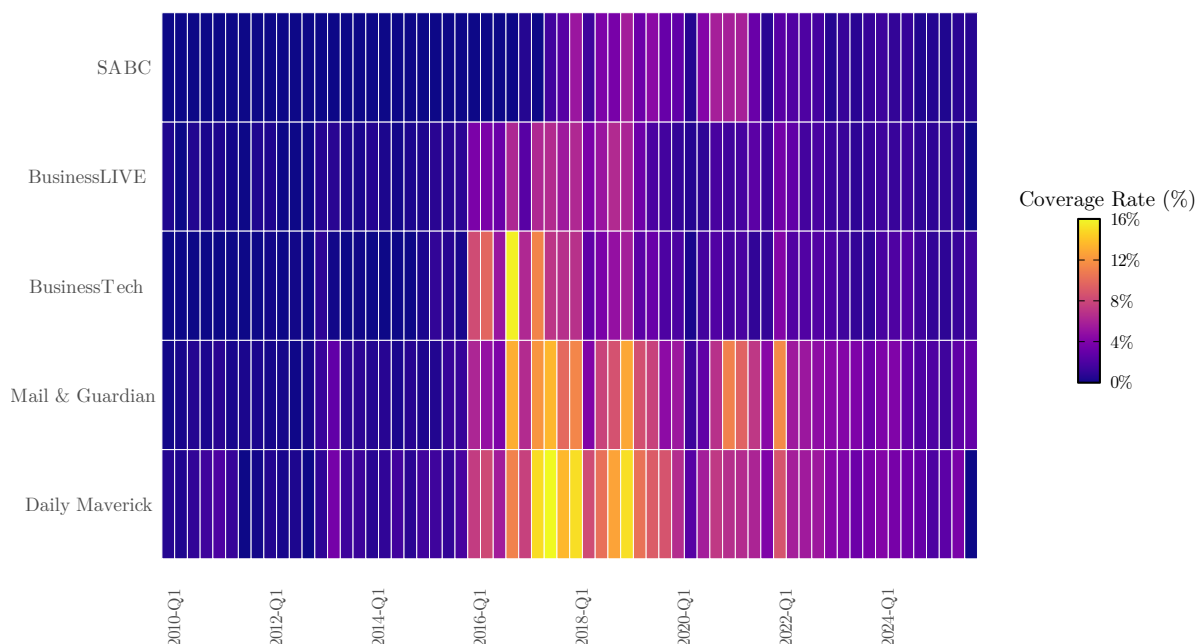


Figure 4: Quarterly State Capture Reporting by Source, 2010–2025

news per quarter. Several patterns emerge from this breakdown. First, the Daily Maverick and Mail & Guardian preceded their competitors in reporting on the issue, with minor jumps in reporting visible around 2011-Q1 and 2013-Q2, the latter most likely linked to the lavish Gupta wedding at Sun City. Early reporting by these two independent, reader-funded news sources reinforces the expectation that such media are more likely to fulfill their journalistic role as watchdogs.

In contrast, the SABC is notably late to begin their reporting on state capture and coverage only exceeds 4 percent per quarter *after* Jacob Zuma was recalled in February 2018. This pattern is consistent with prior expectations.⁵ We argue, however, that the timing of the SABC’s sudden shift in reporting carries some significant implications: Firstly, that Zuma’s departure from the helm of the country also caused a shift in the power dynamics and press freedom of the SABC, perhaps for the better. Secondly, the reporting on state capture and ANC corruption was short-lived and far less pronounced than the opposing “free press.” This limited reporting could be interpreted as a last-resort attempt at regaining consumer confidence in the broadcaster (and the ANC) preceding the May 2019 general elections. Media Monitoring Africa’s report on the public broadcaster’s performance during

⁵Indeed, analysis using our data corroborates Bird and Smith (2019; 2024)’s findings that the SABC’s reporting favors the ANC above other parties on a hierarchical level. However, this ordinality in reporting is not unique to the SABC and often is more reflective of the relative shares of the electorate that vote for them come elections. It remains important to investigate the framing of parties in the news across news sources.

the elections—including investigations of radio and television in 10 of South Africa’s 11 official languages—revealed promising results about SABC’s return to independence and consequent restoration of trust Bird and Smith (2019).

These observations raise further questions. To what extent did control of the broadcaster shift between the Dlamini-Zuma and Ramaphosa factions within the ANC after Zuma’s recall? And to what extent was that control exercised in order to frame or deflect the state capture narrative? The answers are beyond the scope of this report but should serve to inform future research.

Table 3: Average Sentiment Scores for State Capture Articles by Source, 2010–2025

Source	Articles	Bing	AFINN	Positive	Negative	Neutral
Daily Maverick	7,585	−11.10	−17.30	11.7	85.6	2.6
Mail & Guardian	4,612	−8.14	−11.20	14.5	81.4	4.1
BusinessLIVE	10,533	−5.75	−7.56	14.8	78.4	6.8
Business Tech	2,131	−4.91	−7.56	16.0	78.6	5.5
SABC	3,800	−2.76	−5.10	16.8	71.8	11.4
Total	28,661					

Notes: Sentiment scores are calculated per article by summing the overall scores assigned to each emotive word, across scoring category. The last three columns display the share of positive, negative, and neutral news articles over the entire sample of state capture related news pieces. This analysis uses the extended state capture regex pattern.

Table 3 summarises the average sentiment scores across the entire period 2010–2025, assigned by the **bing** and **AFINN** lexicons.⁶ Both measures correlate strongly across different sources and yield plausible results. Using the **bing** classification system, we also report the share of articles that fall within the categories of positive, negative, or neutral.

The Daily Maverick and Mail & Guardian, consistent with their watchdog role, use a higher frequency of scathing language with more negative average sentiment scores (−11.1 and −8.14 on the **Bing** scale, respectively) and the highest shares of negative articles. Furthermore, Daily Maverick has the lowest share of neutral articles, suggesting that its coverage is rarely ambiguous. In stark contrast, the SABC displays the least negative sentiment score at −2.76 (albeit slightly negative, given the inherent nature of corruption). Furthermore, the national broadcaster has the highest share of neutral and positive articles. These results complement Figure 4 and may reflect strategic avoidance of strong and emotive language on the part of the public broadcaster.

It is interesting, however, how the business-focused outlets occupy the middle ground in both first- and second-level agenda-setting measures. This intermediate position may underpin their commitment to professional neutrality—simply reporting economic or governance risks pertaining to state capture—as opposed to the framing of the issue as a political

⁶The **nrc** results have been omitted from this report as they are subject to further analysis.

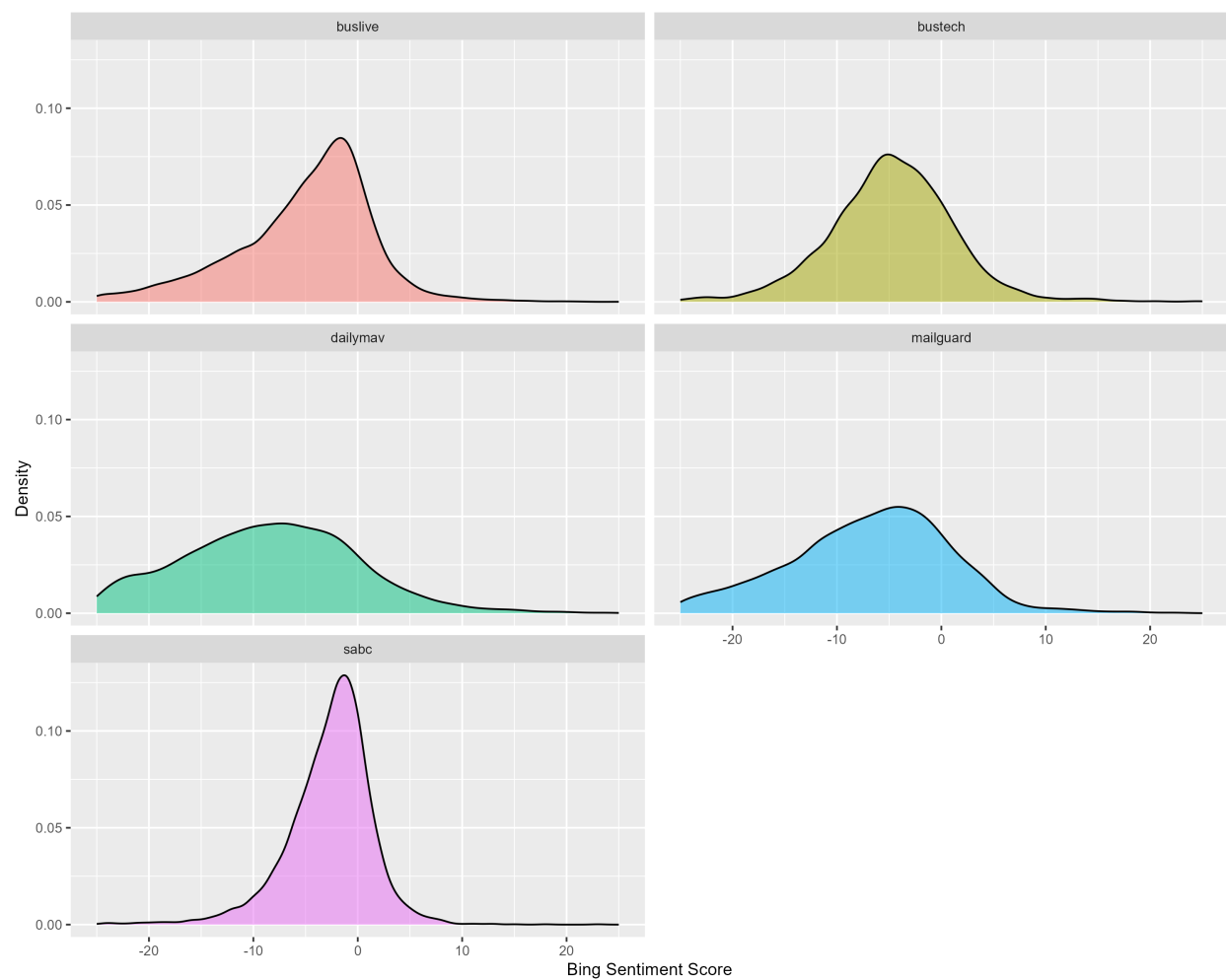


Figure 5: Sentiment Distribution By Source, Bing Scoring, 2010–2025

scandal.⁷ While financial journalism conventionally adopts a more cautious tone, it could also invite suspicion of external pressure or vested interests. A more plausible explanation, however, is the need to maintain a neutral stance for advertising and other commercial stakeholders.

The shapes of the probability distribution functions of Bing sentiment scores in Figure 5 provide another perspective of the results are shown in Table 3. Clearly, the SABC’s sentiment scores are concentrated near zero (or neutral) and aggregate sentiment in a single article rarely ranges below the -10 mark. The commercial and financial newspapers display similar distribution plots with BusinessLIVE displaying a tendency to publish more articles that rank highly negative in sentiment and BusinessTech displaying a preference for more positive articles. BusinessLIVE’s tendency to the negative may echo the BusinessLIVE’s frequent publishing of public opinion pieces that are more likely use more critical language than their regular editorials or routine news pieces. Finally, as expected, the shape of the Daily Maverick and Mail & Guardian distribution plots are dramatically skewed to the right, which serves to show that the independent and free press makes no attempt to sugar-coat their narrative(s). Comparative study of these distributions across a range of topics may provide a helpful guide in noticing how divergent reporting may differ across news agendas.

5 Discussion

This report provides a necessary empirical foundation to the predominantly qualitative history of state capture in South Africa. The data confirm the expectation that independent, reader-funded media is more likely to fulfill their role as watchdogs and act as primary agenda-setters. Outlets such as the Daily Maverick and Mail & Guardian granted the issue early and sustained salience, while their framing was revealed to be starkly critical. Commercial sources, adopting a middle-ground, balanced their tone, likely due to stakeholder considerations. Most critically, however, the public broadcaster—once itself accused of being captured—demonstrated a reporting pattern of delayed and neutral engagement that substantiates its alleged complicity. This triad of responses illustrates how distinct media structures produce different narratives around the same systemic corruption.

Future research could build on these findings as follows: (1) establishing a baseline pattern of reporting across various topics for individual outlets would enable the detection of significant deviations; (2) granular analysis of how editorial framing shifts with changes in media leadership or ownership could help disentangle the influence of individual executives from broader structural factors; (3) a longitudinal analysis of the second-level agenda-setting function of the SABC before and after key political transitions may reveal more precise mechanisms of its entanglement in state capture networks. Such work would propel state capture and media communications research forward whilst also shining a brighter light on the current state of the South African public broadcaster.

⁷It should be noted that these outlets regularly provide short-form articles on the stock market and other financial developments which could cite positive movements of certain stocks in the same breath as negative reactions state capture related news and, as a result, balancing the overall tone of a news piece.

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